Under Imran Khan's government, Sharif had been banned from being covered on the electronic media "because he was a convict". Now, his speech, positing himself as the messiah for Pakistan's economic woes, was being beamed live nationwide on television. A day later, the caretaker Punjab government announced that it had unilaterally suspended his jail sentence for corruption until the hearing of his appeals against the judgment. All of this is pretty unprecedented. PML-N stalwarts and supporters claim that so is Pakistan's political and economic situation. As the country gears up for a delayed general election, probably towards the end of January or in early February—under the constitution, they should have taken place within 90 days of the assemblies being dissolved in early August—it is still teetering on the brink of one of the worst economic crises it has ever experienced.

The threat of a Pakistan default rears its head consistently, with the government scrambling to meet the strict conditions of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) for the next loan tranche to come in. Foreign exchange reserves are down, leading to limits being imposed on importers. Inflation is galloping at upwards of 40 per cent and there is real anger on the street about the cost of living. Steep hikes in electricity and gas tariffs, in the prices of food in particular, and the eroded value of the rupee have meant most people have seen their savings sharply cut into. The number of people falling below the poverty line has risen dramatically. Most analysts expect the upcoming elections to revolve entirely around economics.

FEEL-GOOD NARRATIVE

To his credit, Sharif, too, recognises this and his party has positioned its narrative to address these very concerns. Although he did not present any substantial 'economic roadmap' to get the country out of the current crisis as promised before the Lahore

The imprisoned Imran is blacked out of the electronic media and the PTI top leadership is in detention, in hiding or have switched sides

jalsa, Sharif did focus most of his speech on the deleterious effects of inflation on the common person. In effect, the PML-N has been presenting Nawaz Sharif as a saviour, the out-of-the-box solution for Pakistan's current economic ills. It's a feelgood narrative, banking heavily on nostalgia about 'better days' under Sharif's previous government. The problem, of course, is that some of what Sharif was touting as successes—for example, artificially "holding the dollar to 105 rupees" in 2017, as opposed to the current state of PKR 280 to one USD, or the addition of electricity through expensively priced private power plants—was at least partly responsible for the current mess.

To be sure, Pakistan's economic problems are long-standing, widespread and systemic and Sharif's previous governance was not the only one responsible for the current issues. Mismanagement over the past five years has also certainly played its part. But it's also true that Sharif has no silver bullet at his disposal, much as the PML-N might want to portray that image. But what the PML-N is also relying on—or at least hoping for—is

CASES THAT SHADOW NAWAZ SHARIF

Pakistan's three-time prime minister Nawaz Sharif faces several corruption cases. To contest the general election due in January, he needs to get favourable outcomes on his appeals against the ones in which he has been found guilty

PANAMA PAPERS: The Panama Papers leak showed that Sharif's children—daughter Maryam and sons Hasan and Hussein—owned offshore companies not mentioned in the family's wealth statement, and which they allegedly used to acquire expensive properties. The companies, said investigators, were for laundering money and evading taxes. Though the Supreme Court initially refused to hear the case, Opposition politicians approached the apex court, which ruled that Sharif could continue as PM but that a joint investigative team probe the charges. The two main probes against Sharif arising out of the Panama Papers—Avenfield Apartments case and Al Azizia Steel Company case—were sent to an accountability court.

SALARY NON-DISCLOSURE: The reason cited by the SC to disqualify Sharif from holding office, forcing his resignation, was his alleged non-disclosure of the fact that as chairman of a Dubai-based firm, he was earning 10,000 dirhams from 2006 to 2014.